Ñami — Business Idea

Ñami is an app where restaurants in Cochabamba, Bolivia sell the food they have left over at the end of the day, still in good condition, at 50–70% off. The buyer reserves it, pays with a QR code, and picks it up at the restaurant. We start with students at the Universidad Católica Boliviana (UCB).

Everything below is based on a survey of **23 students** and **9 restaurant and café owners** (October 13–14, 2026).

Is it worth building? Based on the surveys, yes: there is a real need on both sides (20 of the 23 students surveyed cut back on food to save money, and 8 of the 9 restaurants would use the app). But surveys measure intent, not commitment. The next step is to show the mockup to the interested restaurants and students to see who is really in.

1. Who it's for, the problem, and how they solve it today

There are two customers: the person who buys and the restaurant that sells. The vision is to serve anyone who can't afford ~Bs 40 (about $6) for a good meal; we start with students because they are concentrated in one area.

	Buyer (UCB students)	Restaurant near campus
Problem	87% (20 of 23) ate something cheaper or skipped a meal to save money in the last week	6 of 9 have good leftover food every day or several times a week
How they solve it today	Cheap set lunch, cooking at home, snacks, street food, or skipping the meal. Most spend Bs 15–40 per meal	Employees take it home (7 of 9) or it gets thrown away (4 of 9): the restaurant earns Bs 0

Why this matters in Bolivia. Bolivia wastes a lot of good food while eating out keeps getting more expensive:

- **At least 1,800 tonnes of food in perfect condition are thrown away every day** in the Cochabamba metropolitan area, according to the director of the Banco de Alimentos de Bolivia (Los Tiempos).

- **About 15% of the food produced and sold in Bolivia is lost or wasted** along the food chain, according to research by the Banco de Alimentos de Bolivia and UNIVALLE (BAB).
- **Inflation reached 20.4% in 2025, the highest in 36 years** (Correo del Sur), and in 2026 food prices have been its main driver (Correo del Sur).

So the same city has good food going to waste and people who struggle to pay for a full meal. Ñami connects the two, and today no app does this in Bolivia.

2. Competitors and why someone would choose Ñami

Too Good To Go, Cheaf and Karma prove the model works (Cheaf has already rescued over 5 million kilos of food in Latin America), but none of them operate in Bolivia. The real competition is what customers do today.

- **The buyer** gets the same restaurant dish, made that same day, for much less than its regular price.
- **The restaurant** earns money from food that brings in Bs 0 today, and chooses the format: a specific dish or a surprise bag (Too Good To Go only offers bags and Karma only dishes; in the survey it was split 5 to 4).
- **Both** pay with QR Simple, which was 94% of electronic payments in Bolivia in 2025 (Los Tiempos). No card needed.

3. Experiment, what I learned, and what I'm still assuming

I ran two anonymous Google Forms (23 students and 9 restaurant and café owners) to test my riskiest assumption: that restaurants have leftovers and would sell them through an app. Every goal I set before seeing the results was met.

Signal	Goal	Result
Restaurants with frequent leftovers	6 of 10	6 of 9
Restaurants that would use the app	5 of 10	8 of 9
Restaurants that want to try it	3 of 10	7 of 9
Students who cut back on food to save	over 50%	87%
Students who want to be first to try it	over 50%	52% (10 left their email)

Conversations: I also talked with the owner of a café and the owner of a pastry shop. Both would love to try the app and think it would work well.

What I learned and what I changed:

1. **Employees take the leftovers home** (7 of 9); they rarely get thrown away. I'm competing with a staff perk, not with the trash.
2. **There is no single format** (5 prefer dishes, 4 bags): the restaurant chooses.
3. **Restaurants don't worry about the fee** (1 of 9). They worry that regular customers will wait for the discount, and about their image (5 of 9 each): food is posted only after rush hour and in limited portions.
4. **Buyers worry about freshness** (7 of 23): every dish shows what time it was made.

What I'm still assuming: that people will actually pay, and at what price; that owners will sell what their employees take home today; that restaurants will post every day; and that out-of-town students are the best segment (only 5 answered).

4. Smallest useful version, mockup, and how I'd build it

The first version does two things: the buyer reserves and pays for a dish, and the restaurant posts what it has left. No delivery, chat, or other cities.

Flow	Mockup screens	Data behind it
Buyer	1 Home · 2 Dish detail · 3 QR payment · 4 Pickup code · 5 Rate freshness	Freshness (7 of 23) and QR use (94%)

Flow	Mockup screens	Data behind it
Restaurant	6 Today's listings · 7 Post (dish or bag) · 8 Orders and money recovered	Format split 5 to 4; fear that customers will wait for the discount (5 of 9)
Edge states	Buyer: 9 No dishes nearby · 10 Payment not confirmed · Sold out and New inside Home	So no case is left undesigned

The mockup follows checkable accessibility rules: text contrast of 4.5:1 or higher, 44 px touch targets, and states that don't rely on color alone. The full mockup is attached as a PDF.

How I'd build and test it:

1. **This week:** show the mockup to 5 students and 3 restaurants and see if they complete the flow without help.
2. **Weeks 2 to 4:** a simple web app with 3 restaurants near UCB, paying with each restaurant's own QR code.
3. **If it works:** a mobile app with built-in QR payment and automatic fee collection.

5. Pricing, marketing, and first paying customers

The app is free for buyers. Restaurants pay **Bs 2 (about $0.30) per dish sold**, with no fixed cost and nothing to pay if they don't sell.

- **Pricing:** a Bs 35 silpancho sells for Bs 14; the restaurant keeps Bs 12. I asked about Bs 2–3 and 7 of 9 said it was fair or cheap; I chose the lowest. With 20 restaurants selling 5 dishes a day, that's about Bs 5,200 a month.
- **Marketing:** social media showing the real dish and its price, student associations, out-of-town student housing, and QR posters at UCB. For restaurants, in-person visits with the mockup.
- **First customers:** I'll follow up with the owners I surveyed (7 of 9 want to try it) and start with 3 near UCB, with the first month free of fees. The 10 students who left their email will get the launch notice.

6. What I'd test next and what would make me change direction

The next test is a 2-week pilot with 3 restaurants and real sales, to measure whether people actually pay and at what price.

North Star metric: dishes rescued per week, meaning posted dishes that someone bought *and picked up*. Each one is value for everyone at once: the buyer ate well for less, the restaurant earned money from food that brought in Bs 0, one less plate went to the trash, and Ñami earned Bs 2. It counts pickups, not just purchases, because food that is paid for but never collected is still wasted. Downloads or sign-ups would not show any of that. Pilot reference goal: about 50 dishes rescued per week with 3 restaurants (an estimate, not yet based on data).

What I measure	Keep going if…	Change direction if…
Restaurants posting 3+ days a week	2 of 3	0 or 1 of 3
Posted dishes that sell	over 50%	under 20%
Buyers who come back	over 30%	under 10%
Sales at 50% vs 70% off	sells the same at 50%	only sells at 70%

If restaurants don't post, I'll start with bakeries and cafés instead: 2 of 3 bakeries throw food away, and all 3 would use the app. **If students don't buy** but people in the area do, I'll switch the starting point to office workers and neighbors.